

common and even less to talk about. That's just my rudimentary observation.

So if you're going into the second marriage thinking that you needed only to be married to a different person to be happy, think again. And if you had money problems in the first marriage, count on a repeat in the second and third, when you'll probably have even less money to fight over. Blended families are also an expensive proposition. Child support costs are often associated with the first and subsequent marriages, and they follow you down the aisle.

Here's another interesting fact: Late-in-life divorce, or "gray divorce," is on the rise, with many of those proceedings initiated by women who'd rather spend their twilight years alone than in a dead marriage. *But that has created yet another drop in wealth.* In a recent AARP study, 26 percent of couples who got divorced between the ages of forty and seventy-nine reported financial problems. That means late-in-life poverty is a possibility, despite years of disciplined savings and investments.

I talk a lot about separating money and emotions. But I know few people who've successfully pulled that off during divorce proceedings. In fact, divorce is often where emotions reach their crescendo. It's ugly, ugly business. But it's big, big business—\$28 billion a year, to be exact. Figures vary across the country, but estimates on the average cost of a divorce range from \$15,000 to \$30,000. Between court and lawyer's fees and custody and support negotiations, many couples pay closer to \$100,000. But the only number you really have to remember is this: The average divorce lawyer charges \$200 to \$300 *an hour*. Lawyers in certain parts of the United States command closer to \$1,000 an hour. Every battle, every dispute, and every disagreement is money in a lawyer's pocket. The greater the conflict, the greater the cost.

The best way to minimize cost is to seek as much parity as possible *before lawyers get involved*. Counseling and mediation are infinitely cheaper. Or you could end up like Janice and Ian, a couple who split after the birth of their second son, after a decade of marriage.

You'd never know it now, but one look at their wedding photo would show you that Ian and Janice were once madly in love. Even their friends would admit they'd have bet money this couple would